

THE ROFL UNIVERSE

Five years ago close to 1,000 people gathered on the campus of MIT to attend a sold-out conference devoted to the question "What is awesome on the Internet?" The event included presenters from many prestigious institutions but what they had gathered to examine, is what might be called the ROFL universe. <http://dgit.in/roflld>

THE MAN WITH THE GOLDEN BLOOD

What if someone seemed to be lacking Rh antigens all together? That would make this blood type one of the rarest in the world. Meet the donors, patients, doctors and scientists involved in the complex global network of rare – and very rare – blood. <http://dgit.in/gldnbl>

HOSTILE TAKE OVER

What's it like to have Google and Amazon try to kill your startup? Is it a David vs. Goliath story? Fusion magazine speaks to Marco Zappacosta whose company Thumbtack finds itself in this tricky situation. Should he hold his ground? Find out what he plans to do: <http://dgit.in/dvsgol>

OUT OF THE ASHES

It took a lot of fossil fuels to forge our industrial world. Now they're almost gone. Could we do it again without them? Lewis Dartnell, a UK Space Agency research fellow at the University of Leicester examines all possible angles in this long but worthwhile read: <http://dgit.in/humanity2>

So, what's the deal with net neutrality?

You've probably seen the AIB video, but there's more to net neutrality than just that.

– By Nikhil Pradhan

If you've been plugged in to social networks over the past month or so, you must have spotted some of your friends share or talk about articles on net neutrality. And while I assume many of you understand the concept in question and have already formed opinions, there will also be some of you out there who have got no idea what everybody's on about. If you fall in the latter category, then I'd also assume you must have a few questions. So, to help you better understand the ins and outs of net neutrality, let's tackle a few basic questions one by one.

What is net neutrality?

If net neutrality was to be defined in a single line it would go like this:

"The premise of net neutrality is that all data on the Internet should be treated equally."

Expanding on the above, a more comprehensive definition would be:

"Net neutrality means that Internet Service Providers (companies like Airtel, Reliance etc., who are responsible for your broadband and mobile Internet connections) shouldn't be allowed to give preferential treatment to select websites, online services or apps. These ISPs should also not be allowed to discriminate against any website, online service or application."

Let's now break up the above definition for the sake of clarification.

Preferential treatment: This means that ISPs can't ask some websites, online services or apps to pay extra in order to make it easier for consumers to access

them. For instance, Airtel shouldn't be allowed to take money from Flipkart and then let Airtel broadband and mobile Internet customers load the Flipkart website faster, or scrap all data charges when the Flipkart app is being used.

Discrimination: Conversely, an ISP shouldn't be allowed to penalise websites, online services or apps because they haven't paid extra charges. Continuing the same example from above, Airtel shouldn't be allowed to put competing e-commerce websites like Snapdeal or Amazon at a disadvantage by giving Flipkart a boost just because Flipkart paid up.

Why should I care/know about net neutrality?

If you use the Internet in any shape or form today, net neutrality affects you directly. If the Telecom Regulatory Authority of India (TRAI) takes the side of telcos and ISPs in this matter then you will see a considerable change in the way you visit websites or use apps. One of the darkest possible future scenarios in this timeline would be to have the Internet divided up into slices of websites and services, similar to how your DTH provider offers channels. According to this timeline, you would have to pay extra on top of your recurring

